



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with DB

DB Transcript

Interview with DB

Conducted online on 17 June 2021

Interviewer Olivia Dee.

Transcribed by Olivia Dee

DB (who was born in the 1960s) was interviewed online due to the ongoing COVID-19 pandemic. She explained that she was adopted after her birth mother had given birth to her after spending time in Thorndale House mother and baby home, which was operated by the Salvation Army in Belfast. DB related her frustration and sadness that when she tried to trace her birth mother, she was told the records did not enable an identification to be made. When this was corrected, some years later, her birth mother had passed away. DB also offered the details of her first pregnancy, which occurred when she was fifteen. Her adoptive mother tried to force through DB's baby's adoption but DB resisted this. She married the father of her baby when she reached the age of 16 and went to Hopedene mother and baby home to collect her infant child. The young couple raised her themselves. The final stages of the interview discussed DB's relationship with her first daughter and the problematic reactions of her own birth mother's other children to her arrival in their lives: they had not been told about DB's existence.

Names are redacted to protect the anonymity of DB and her family and others mentioned in the recording. Where redactions have been made this is indicated by **. References to DB's mother, father, grandfather all refer to her adopted family. References to birth mother or birth father refer to her biological parents.

OD: Great. So that's the sign that it's being recorded and then when its...

DB: Ok.

OD: If you want me to stop at any time, you'll hear a voice that says "this meeting is not being recorded" or ... you know ... something like that so you'll know that I've stopped recording. So just, just for the tape it's the 17th of June 2021. I'm Olivia Dee and this is the ... the mother and baby home project in Northern Ireland and I'm here with an interviewee who's going to remain anonymous and we're going to talk a bit about your experience. So that's all we need for the introductions, so ... We talked a bit about this before we put the tape on, about limitations or anything that you don't want to talk about, so you're aware of that and you're still happy for me to record and to carry on?

DB: Yes, yes.

OD: So could you tell me first of all what your connection is to the project? Why, why it is that you originally kind of got in contact and what, what your experience was, sort of, overall?

OD: I was born in Thorndale House and ... the Salvation Army home on the Antrim Road. I don't really, you know, I don't have any memories of that at all ... but when I went to find my birth mother, she was deceased when I, you know, when I got there. But I got contact with her sister who knew all about me and there was three older siblings that didn't know anything about me. What I would class then, her sister, as my aunt, she is now deceased. She actually told me that she was there for three months with me and it was her mother [DB's grandmother] that forced her to go back home and to give me up for adoption,

because there was three other mouths to feed and she was divorced from her husband; where the three older siblings came from. And then I have no idea where my father, birth [father], whatever ... wherever he came ... I have no idea who he is, none. All I know is he was a van driver.

OD: And who so ... that's, that's really interesting. I'm so sorry that you didn't manage to get in contact with your mother before ... before it was too late. That's ... that's hard and I can't imagine that. Yeah. So, let's start ... let's start chronologically then. So, you know that your ... so your mother... was your mother in Thorndale with you for three months once you were born, or was she there ... sorry was your mother ... was your mother there for three months once you were born?

DB: No, she must have went in before that. No ... no one has discussed that with me, but, she ... because the older siblings; the eldest was ten, and she [knew] absolutely nothing about me. So, she must have been away and the grandmother was a very big presence and actually I think because my birth mother worked, it was the grandmother that reared the three of them. They all lived in the one house.

OD: Ok, so when your ... when your mother went to Thorndale, you think it was your ... your grandmother, your sort of 'birth' grandmother who was the ... the driving force behind that; based on what your aunt told you?

DB: Her and a minister is what my aunt told me. Her and a minister and because it ... there was the three other ... other mouths to feed, and she was a woman on her own. Then she was made, according to my aunt, to give me up because they couldn't afford another child. She couldn't afford another one. So, she stayed with me ... she stayed with me in Thorndale House right up until

near December, near Christmas ... That's what I'm led to believe. And the day they took me away, I believe it was very, very traumatic. I had to be pulled out of her arms and it was, it was very traumatic for her so it was. That is what my aunt had told me. And then when she arrived home, she spent a couple of days in bed, you know, crying, trying to deal with this. And then when I did find ... when I ... when we were entitled to go and find who we were, when it became law, as I say, three siblings did not know about me. But the middle one, when ... when she [DB's birthmother] was dying ... she died of lung cancer and she lived with him, he looked after her, and she kept saying to him: "Find my daughter." And he said to her: "No your daughter's on her way down," because she had one daughter. It was two sons and the eldest girl and she kept saying to him: "No. Find my daughter" and he couldn't understand this because none of them knew anything about me.

OD: That's so heart breaking. I'm so sorry.

DB: Yeah, yeah. And it seemed actually that when she had given me up, she turn ... she actually became an alcoholic, so she did ...

OD: And that's the trauma of the experience and just being ... being so unhappy to have lost you?

DB: Yeah.

OD: And ... that's so sad. How old was your mum ... your birth mother ...

DB: When she gave birth to me, she was thirty-three...

OD: Thirty-three?

DB: and I ... she was thirty-three. I actually ... just before it became law here ... because I have ... before we all went digitalising things, your medical records always were kept in ... it's like a brown envelope, not an envelope ... how would you say? Like a wee brown file thing.

OD: Yeah, like a folder.

DB: My ... yeah, my first address on that was Thorndale House ... on my medical ... when the doctor would have, you know, when you'd've went into the doctor and your records were sitting with no computers or anything and he would have brought your notes out of this wee file thing and my first address on this was Thorndale House. And a couple of times, I would have been a teenager, I asked the doctors what this address was? What is this? Well, I got brushed off with them and ... "Oh no that's, that's just a medical thing. That's just a medical thing". But then my GP that was with me there right up until he retired, I asked him one day and I was a bit older and I said to him: "What is that address?" And he told me that it was a Salvation Army mother and baby home. And I said: "Oh right, OK." Now I knew I was adopted...

OD: Yeah.

DB: ... because my mother always made it known that I was adopted. This is my own mum, not my birth mum, my own mum. And she was not the sort of person you could speak to. You couldn't discuss anything with her. And he was able to tell me ... it was a Doctor *name redacted* that delivered me, so it was. So, I wrote to Thorndale House and I had ... I had the letter. It's ... I meant to get it out, and it states on it that the only thing they had for my date of birth was

a married lady, but they didn't think it was anything to do with me and they give me no details, so they didn't. But I still have the letter.

OD: And you ... so you ... you had written to say, you know, I ... I just want some more information, I'm trying to track this down, yeah, and they said that there was no record of you other than this married lady?

DB: Which was ... which was her.

OD: So, it turned out it was it was her?

DB: It was her and she was still alive at that time. When I wrote she was still alive. But then when it became law and I had to do, you know, a few meetings with social workers and things before I was given any detail ... she was dead, so she was ... so ... yeah.

OD: Why ... why do you think ... do you think that was a mistake or do you think that was intentional that they had told you that it was nothing to do with your mother or ...?

DB: I ... I honestly ... I don't know, I don't know. At the time when I received the letter back, I didn't question it. I just thought 'alright okay', you know? I ... I just didn't want to do with it, and I couldn't go any further with it because it wasn't law here. I just didn't know what to think and then I would never have dreamt off the likes of the Salvation Army and things and all, dismissing, you know? I didn't think ... I ... it's entirely different now how I think but then it was ... that was the truth to me, you know? That ...

OD: Yeah.

DB: ... because ...

OD: If someone ... if someone tells you that then you ... then you assume that that's correct, you know, I understand that completely.

DB: Yeah.

OD: I'm just so sorry that you missed ... that that chance wasn't given to you, that ... that's awful.

DB: Yeah.

OD: So, you said that you don't know much about the birth father other than he was a van driver, was that ... was your aunt the one who told you that? Ok.

DB: Yes.

OD: And your mother ...

DB: She actually ... sorry ... she actually, a couple of times went to tell me his name and I stopped her and I don't know why. I stopped her because I had such a good relationship with my dad and with my grandfather, I think I just put that to the back of my head ... that I had been through this trying to find my birth mother and she was dead. I did not want to do all this again and I think that's why, you know, I kept ... I didn't want to know.

OD: I completely understand ...

DB: Yeah.

OD: ... that that makes so much sense, I completely understand. Okay wow. So you, you know, that you were born there due to your birth certificate. But you weren't given any information about that, and that when you had asked GPs ahead ... before your GP finally told you, other doctors had sort of brushed it off and said that it wasn't, you know, don't worry that's just like an admin thing or something, and then you were finally told by your GP what it [Thorndale House] actually [was]? How old were you when you started looking for your ... when did the law change for you? What age were you?

DB: I was thirty-three.

OD: Thirty-three?

DB: And that was the age she had had me.

OD: Did you have a ... did you have a good relationship with your adoptive family? Was it ... was it something ... you said that your ... your mum was quite open that you were adopted? What ... what did that mean for you when you were growing up? Was it hard? Was it fine?

DB: No, when I say my mum was quite open, my mum made it very obvious she ... I remember one day vividly ... and my mum had these brasses, you know, the brasses years ago? You used to clean and polish and things ... and my mum was cleaning ... we lived in a kitchen house, two-up two-down, [at] the time. And my mum was standing at the door, but the door opened into the living room, and she was cleaning the brasses and Daddy and I were sitting cleaning the brasses that were on the hearth ... and I honestly don't know what

... I have no idea what age I was but she ... she said to my Dad: "Tell her what she is ... tell her." And Daddy says: "Stop it now, stop it!"

And she started shouting: "Tell her what she is! Tell her what she is!"

And I said: "Daddy, Daddy what am I?"

And he says: "You're nothing love, you're nothing."

And she shouted: "Yes you are. You're a bastard!"

And I never ... it was a Sunday and I never forget that day. But she always made it known like that, that you don't ... I went and spoke to neighbours ... sorry (DB becomes emotional here)

OD: You take your time.

DB: I went ... I went, spoke to neighbours because we were a small street and everybody, you know, we weren't inside each other's houses, but our street was like a small community and ... but once I was married and had my children and things, I went one night to see a lady that lived two doors up from us because she wasn't well. And I had spoke to her and said to her that I actually had found out who my birth mother was. And she started crying and said: "I'm delighted love, I'm delighted." And I ... but then I said she was deceased. So, then she started talking and she had said about ... she would have ... she did old-time dancing, the neighbour, and she actually danced with my aunt, my birth mother's sister, but nobody knew this, you know: who, how ... And my actual aunt would've come over to this neighbour's house when I could have been playing about the street. But the neighbour said to me: "If I had've known she was your aunt love, I would have taken you back years ago." Because, seemingly, when I was small child, they ... and I said to the neighbour: "Was it when I'm growing, up was I cheeky? You know, as a teenager, cheeky? Backchat?" And she said: "No love you were learning to the walk, you were hanging onto the sofa and trying to put yourself along the sofa", and she says,

“we had to go in many’s the time and lift you out because of the beatings you were getting.”

OD: From your mother? From your adopted mother?

DB: Yeah. Yeah. I lived with that all my life, so I did.

OD: What ... what ... do you know what the circumstances were of your adoption? Do, you know, why you were adopted by that particular family? What ... what it was ...

DB: No. I ... I ... We lived in a house that was my grandfather's. It was only rented but it was my grandfather's, and my grandfather ... my uncle, my mum's youngest brother still lived there. My grandfather lived there. It was my mum, my dad and me. We were in a two bedroomed house, so my grandfather spent a lot of time and a lot of money on me. I went to prep school. I went to elocution lessons. I danced ... I did ballroom and danced for my country and ... and my mum always seemed to be jealous of me.

OD: Right.

DB: And she hated my grandfather spending money on me ... I spent most of my time with my grandfather. When he'd of come home from work ... he worked in the shipyard, he would've had his tea and then him and I would have went out and as I say, we walked the roads, we went to parks. My grandfather seemed take me out the house. And then Saturdays he would have taken me to [the] pictures and out for our tea and all those things. My grandfather ... my grandfather was a big presence in my life.

OD: Yeah, and were you closer...

DB: So he was.

OD: Were you closer to your father as well? ... [delay in the online audio] I'm so sorry there was a slight delay, so I accidentally spoke over you. Just carry on.

DB: No, she seemed to be very, very jealous of me and then my grandfather took ill and ended up in *name of hospital redacted*. He (inaudible) that affected the brain. The day he died I arrived home from school and there was nobody in, and ... we'd two doors, front door and the inside door, so the big door was closed. So, my mum's aunt lived down the street and I went down to her, and I says to her: "My mum's not in", because mummy was always in. And she says: "No you've to go on around" [to] ...' and this was *name redacted*, my aunt's dad. "You've to go on round", and she shooed me out of the house. And when I went around to my aunt's mum's and dad's house, they just made me a cup of tea and given me a biscuit and then my mum and my aunt arrived back. But I didn't know where they had been. And then went on round home. But there was nothing said to me. And then the next morning, [pause, DB became emotional] ... this coffin arrived. And I didn't know who was in it. I'd no ... to this day nobody ever told me that my grandfather had died. Nobody ever told me. And the coffin was opened, and it was my grandad. Nobody sat me down and spoke to me or told me or [DB very emotional here] ... nothing. So they didn't. And then, things just went ... I was ... my daughter's will laugh and all, you know ... I was an only child for twelve years. I was grandad's little princess and I was, but then it all went the opposite way. You talk about going from rags to riches, I went from riches to rags. My shoes, I had holes in the soles of my shoes, my feet were swollen when I got to school, I wasn't ... I

actually then went to ... from a prep [school] to a secondary. Everything just changed dramatically.

OD: Yeah.

DB: So, it was. Yeah.

OD: Were you ... were you still close with your father? Your adopted father?

DB: You see my dad didn't ... he was there but it wasn't a big presence. He worked all day. I know my grandfather worked all day, but my grandfather was a big presence in my life. My dad didn't really ... when I say he didn't come in to it ... he was there, but it was my grandfather was the big presence ... So it was. So then, that was ... my grandfather died in 197*, so then in *two years later*, I was fifteen, and I ended up pregnant. I was six months before my mum and dad found out.

OD: Did you ... did you know? Did you know before six months?

DB: Yeah.

OD: Ok.

DB: I hid it. I was terrified. I knew what was coming. So, six months ... she tried to get me a backstreet abortion and the neighbours had told her she would kill me if she done that, but she still tried to do it. She had ... now I lived my life hammered, [inaudible], beat. I lived my life like that so then I knew what was coming. So, nobody would do an abortion on me. She took me to the GP; the GP actually put her out of the surgery and put her out onto the street. Yeah,

she tried throwing punches at me in the GP surgery. They put her outside. So, it ended up she took me to up to Hopedene. She took me up to Hopedene and was putting me in Hopedene. That my baby was being adopted. My uncle, that was at home when I was growing up - mum's younger brother - he had said that: "No, I wasn't going into any home while he'd a roof over his head." He had married at this stage and had no family, so he took me in. I stayed out in their flat, but I wasn't allowed out over the door in case anybody seen me. I wasn't allowed back down home again to see my dad, or anybody, in case anybody seen me. I had to stay in the flat. It was like a prison sentence. I never seen anybody. Nobody was allowed to contact me. It was like being in jail. My aunt used to go out in the mornings on the twenty past seven bus. My uncle went at seven to go to work. My aunt went the twenty past seven bus, down to her mum's and I was left on my own the whole day. This was every day. I just had to sit in that flat. So, this went on till I went into labour. And my mum had me booked in to the *hospital redacted*. So, I was taken over ... my uncle and my aunt took me over to *hospital redacted*. The roads and everything were barricaded at the time, you know, it was really ... but we got through and I went into the *hospital redacted*. I was ... I ... I was taken into this big room and it was ... I can still see it ... there was beds all round it and it there was women and the women were moaning, shouting, but it was a big room and they were on beds and I couldn't understand. And that was Saturday morning, and I couldn't understand ... and they ... I never seen my aunt and uncle. They weren't allowed in with me; I wasn't allowed [anyone with her]. I was just put on into this bed and I was on my own. My aunt and uncle left me at the door. And I was on my own. So yeah, I went into labour. There was ... there a sister or a matron, I don't know. And I must have been screaming, I don't know, and ... when I was giving birth, and she lifted her hand ... I never forgot it, and she smacked my legs and my backside and told me to "stop screaming!" [and asked] where did I think I was? And then she smacked me again. So, then I had a baby, so then it

was taken into the ward. No, I was taken ... I remember going over to *hospital building*. I was taken from the *hospital building*. I was taken in an ambulance ...

OD: OK.

DB: ... that same night and I was taken over ... and I was put in a big, big ward, but I don't ... what stays with me vividly is, there was rioting and you could see all these ... because there were ... the ward was ... you could see out and it was *location redacted*, and I don't know what they were burning but things were burning and ... you could ... you could see the flames and everything and I remember that so vividly. So that was all on the Saturday night, and I never seen any ... I never seen no one. This all on my own. I was in a ward with women with other babies, but I didn't have a baby. I didn't have ... I'd *had* [places emphasis on word] a baby but I didn't have a baby. And nobody told me what this baby was, so ... on the Sunday visiting was allowed, and I think it was 3 to 4 and my mum and my dad come up. But it was ... it was as if I had got my tonsils out. Because nobody talked about a baby, and I still didn't know what I had. My mum and dad just talked trivial things, and I didn't have the baby with me ... the baby ... Once the baby was born, that was it, she was gone, but I didn't know at this stage it was a she. Once she was born, she was gone. So, on the Sunday ... some of the ... the ward I was in the ladies all had their babies and some of the ladies had spoke to me and said to me about me being so young, blah-de-blah and where was my baby?

And I said: "I don't know."

And she said: "What did you have?"

And I said: "I don't know. Nobody has told me."

"Oh no that's not right!"

And I said: "No, nobody's told me. I don't know."

So then, on the Monday ... and a social worker ... because my mum, my mum involved social workers, my mum also involved Probation Board, but the girls in the Probation Board kept me coming over to the office because they kept saying to me: “you haven't done anything wrong and we don't know why you're here but we want you to come because then we know you're OK”. And that's what the girls in the office said to me: “we know you're OK.” The social worker at the time was Miss *redacted*. That was her name, I'll never forget it. So, it was on ... they kept you in a full week then, for first babies, from Saturday to Saturday. And I ... Miss *redacted* came to me, I think it was the Friday; but nobody had talked about babies to me. But before she came, I had, as you get up and go to bathroom and things and during the week and I could hear this baby crying in this room. And it ... it was a door, it wasn't a ward, it was a door and there was a baby crying and I could ... [DB was upset here and speaking through tears] One at the desk ... I opened the door and the nurse ... a nurse came running at me and I only had opened it because I could hear a baby crying. And ... I seen in that room and in that room was just a cot, there was nothing else, just a cot with this baby in in. I didn't know it was mine. But ... and this baby was crying, and they put me out and they closed the door. And I asked: “Is that my baby?” And the nurse just dismissed me and put me back. Told me to go back to bed. So, on the Friday *social worker* came and said to me: “DB, do you want to see your baby?”

And I says: “I'd like to know what it is.”

And she says to me: “Oh you have a wee girl.” And she says: “Would you like to see her before I take her away?”

And I says: “Yes please.”

I wasn't allowed to lift her. I wasn't allowed to touch her. I was only allowed to look at her. And *social worker* then took her away, and I asked where she was going and I was told not to worry, she'd be okay. So, I don't know where I got the strength from or where I got the backbone from, and I think maybe it's

because I was adopted; I was not letting anyone put this wee girl of mine through what I went through. I wasn't doing it! And a school friend of mine actually ended up in Hopedene and they were allowed in and out of Hopedene, and I actually run into her one day. I was ... and she said to me: "Do you know, where your wee baby is?"

And I says to her: "No."

And she says to me: "It's in Hopedene."

And I says: "Are you sure?"

And she says: "Yes."

So I asked *social worker* could I go up and see her and she told me "no". And she said to me that, you know, "How did you find out ... who told you that your baby's there? Your baby's not there."

And I says: "No, it's just some friend had said."

And she said: "No."

But I actually made arrangements because this schoolfriend I had, she was in there and she was living in there and she was pregnant. They were feeding the babies and things, you know, they were looking after the babies in Hope ... ah Thorndale ... no, Hopedene. So, she actually arranged with me one day to come up to the side window, to let me see her. But as I went up there was a lady come out and told me to go away. So, I didn't get to see her, so I didn't. So, I fought my mum tooth and nail. I kept in contact with *social worker* and ... and the guy that I had my daughter to and we got married. So that I could sign, because I was under sixteen, I wasn't sixteen till the *month redacted*. I ... I was sixteen on the *date redacted* and my mum wouldn't let me get married on *date redacted*. [DB's mother said] "What would the neighbours say? Get married on the *one day after her sixteenth birthday*." So [I] got married *one day after sixteenth birthday* and went straight to Hopedene. I come out of the church and went to Hopedene, so I did. And got her. I just wasn't putting her through what I went through, so I wasn't. So ...

OD: I can't ... I can't believe how strong you are.

DB: I'm not, I'm falling apart.

OD: You are. That was incredible.

DB: I think, in saying all that ... my eldest daughter hasn't spoke to any of us in years. I've two other daughters to my husband, who I did marry and who I'm still with. My daughter doesn't seem to be able to bond. I've tried so hard with her, but now it's all ... I don't know. I think it's all just coming back and I can't live with it and I'm struggling so badly, I am. I'm attending the trauma team and things, and they're trying to diagnose me with PTSD because of the trauma I have been through. And that's why I agreed to this because I feel I never really opened up to anybody. I've never ... I've never been able, really, to go from there to there, if that makes sense? And I ... I'm trying to deal with all that and it's ... maybe it's just cause I'm older or whatever, I'm just struggling now. I'm struggling, so I am. Yeah ... I haven't seen my eldest daughter in years, so I haven't.

OD: I think that you're ... you're seeing the trauma team is really important and I'm really relieved to hear that because I think everything that you're saying just ... I can't emphasise enough how, how difficult that must have been and how incredible it was that you had, you had done that and got through that and that's ... It's incredible but of course it has repercussions, of course it does. But what that social what ... what that probation officer had said to you is absolutely correct that none of this is your fault, none of it. And that's ... that's maybe hard ... hard to grasp when you're younger because when you're fifteen I can't imagine how terrifying it is to be in a situation where I'm guessing you didn't

understand the, the nature of labour, of giving birth, of all the difficulties and the pain that go alongside that and to do that outside of a supportive environment in itself it's traumatic. But everything that went before it and everything that came after will have compacted that and made it more difficult so I'm ... I'm so glad that you that you have that help and we, we can we can talk after the interview's over about what ... what other help is available and how else that ... that ... we might be able to do something with that but I just, I just think ... I'm so glad that you were at least told when you were fifteen by someone, even if it wasn't your family, but you were told that that [it] wasn't your fault because nothing is ... nothing you've said is your fault. It's all, it's all things that should have been dealt with very differently and weren't ... and, and being treated like that at fifteen ... being treated like that at thirty-three is, is awful. Being treated like that at fifteen of course leads to, to other problems.

DB: Yeah.

OD: But what you what you told me is the most incredible, incredible show of ... of your own determination to not relive what you had experienced and I think the cruelty of that is that you, you [were] unable to reach, you know, your mum in time and that's ... that needs to be recorded. We have ... like I said we have to make people aware that that barrier was put up to you and that again is not your fault.

DB: I never remember as a child her lifting me on to her knee. I never remember being on her knee, never getting a hug. I never remember any affection from my mum whatsoever. None.

OD: Which is heart breaking.

DB: None. Up until the day she died.

OD: I'm just ... hang on sorry I don't want to lose you [the interviewer's computer was running out of battery] ... sorry I didn't want to lose you my battery was low. Yeah no I ... I can't, I can't I ... the story is heart breaking, it is, and what you've done through it and I think the one constant throughout it has been your bravery in how you've ... how you chosen to learn from the experience and try to, try to avoid it happening again and that story of you, you know, going through all of that to bring your baby home is, is so moving and I know that the relationship is different now and it's difficult but you did that at fifteen. That's incredible. I don't even know how you found the strength to do that.

DB: Neither do I now!

OD; And, and you're working with the trauma team and working with that network that, that might do something in the future to help you repair that relationship but you, you can't yeah it it's so difficult to know how to navigate those things when you're yourself dealing with what, you know, what you've been diagnosed with which I don't know if you've had that diagnosis yet but PTSD.

DB: No.

OD: No. But just if you do end up getting it that will be a way to kind of tackling some of these issues and [to] think carefully about how to do that and I'm really grateful that you have spoken to us because I can't imagine how difficult that was either. So I'm, I'm really grateful that you've spoken to us and all I can do is add my voice to that and say that none of this is your fault. This is

... this is all horrible circumstances and, and you've pushed through them in a way that's just incredible. Just incredible. And the story ... the story you told is amazing and just, I'm really grateful that others are going to hear it because I think there's a lot of similarities between what you said and what's, what's appeared in other people's stories as well. Like, I think it's really hard because everyone's story is different but there's so many constants running through it and I, I just want to add that voice to the others and so people can see that and, and know what it is that women went through when they experienced this.

DB: Yeah.

OD: Is there anything ... is there anything else that you'd like to discuss while we ... while we're talking? Is there anything that you feel we haven't covered? Is there anything ... I feel like you ... perhaps one of the most beautifully told stories we've had so far in terms of how you navigated me through it. So, I don't ... I don't feel like I've lost anything. I think you told it brilliantly. I sort of stayed quiet for the last forty-five minutes really because I didn't want ... I didn't want to interrupt what you were saying because it was you clearly have such a good hold on that story.

DB: Yeah, I just feel I need it to tell *someone* it. You know, I don't know it just ... to try to help me deal with it I had to share it so I did.

OD: Yeah.

DB: Yeah. As far as the adopted family and are ... the birth family and things, none of that worked out. They all, they also thought "what are you after?" Nothing. And but not, with not knowing about me and with it being such a closed secret, and then I had trouble with the youngest [son of DB's

birthmother] ... it was a guy, and I ended up having to get the police and exclusion orders and all that was crazy. So, yeah, but I wouldn't go down that road again [laughs ruefully].

OD: So, is the only person that you've had sort of positive contact with in your birth family would be your aunt?

DB: Yes.

OD: Would you, would you ... I don't want to put words in your mouth? Is that positive or is that just that it was friendlier than usual, or ...

DB: It was, it was very positive and she knew about me and she was able to help me, you know, with ... she actually ... I got photographs and things of my birth mum from her and she was able to build a picture for me...

OD: Yeah.

DB: which really, really helped, so she did it. Yeah, yeah.

OD: I'm sorry, I'm sorry that you have had difficulty with that. I think a lot of the people we speak to either have a positive story with a birth family or they, they have a very fractured story with the birth family, and I think it just speaks to the difficulty of the situation and how it, it's not as seamless a solution as people seem to think it was, you know. That, that, will always come with complications and I think that's what's so frustrating is, you know, when birth mothers are told, you know, you can't keep a baby you can't do this, you know ... you're either too young, or you're divorced or you're still widowed or single, all these things they're told are going to be these impossible complications and

actually equally impossible complications come from, from the other aspect of it as well so ...

DB: Yeah.

OD: Yeah. [interviewee is interrupted by her husband] I'm glad you have someone there I wasn't sure if you if you had someone with you this afternoon. So that's important. I ... what about your family, your, your daughters, your other daughters, you know, that this family unit that you have now, do you have support there?

DB: Yes my, my daughters are great. I have a great relationship with them and their children, my grandchildren.

OD: You have grandchildren, oh I'm so happy.

DB: Yeah. I had three daughters and I now have five grandsons.

OD: Wow that's amazing, I'm so happy to hear that. That's really that's ... it's ... it's the one redeeming thing about these interviews is just the families that are created out of these tragedies are always so just lovely and I can tell you a good grandmother and all of these things that I bet that there ... I bet you're so special to them and that's, that's lovely I'm so glad to hear that. If you're finished and happy then I'll turn the recording off and will have a quick chat about some of the options that we have so let me, let me...

[Interview ends]